AMERICA FEDERAL (1780-1820)

History of Interior and Furniture
Chair research
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Figure 1: Parlor from the James Duncan Jr. house, Haverhill, Massachusetts



Figure 2: Urn motifs on fireplace in Parlor

SKETCH AND ORDINARY PICTURE

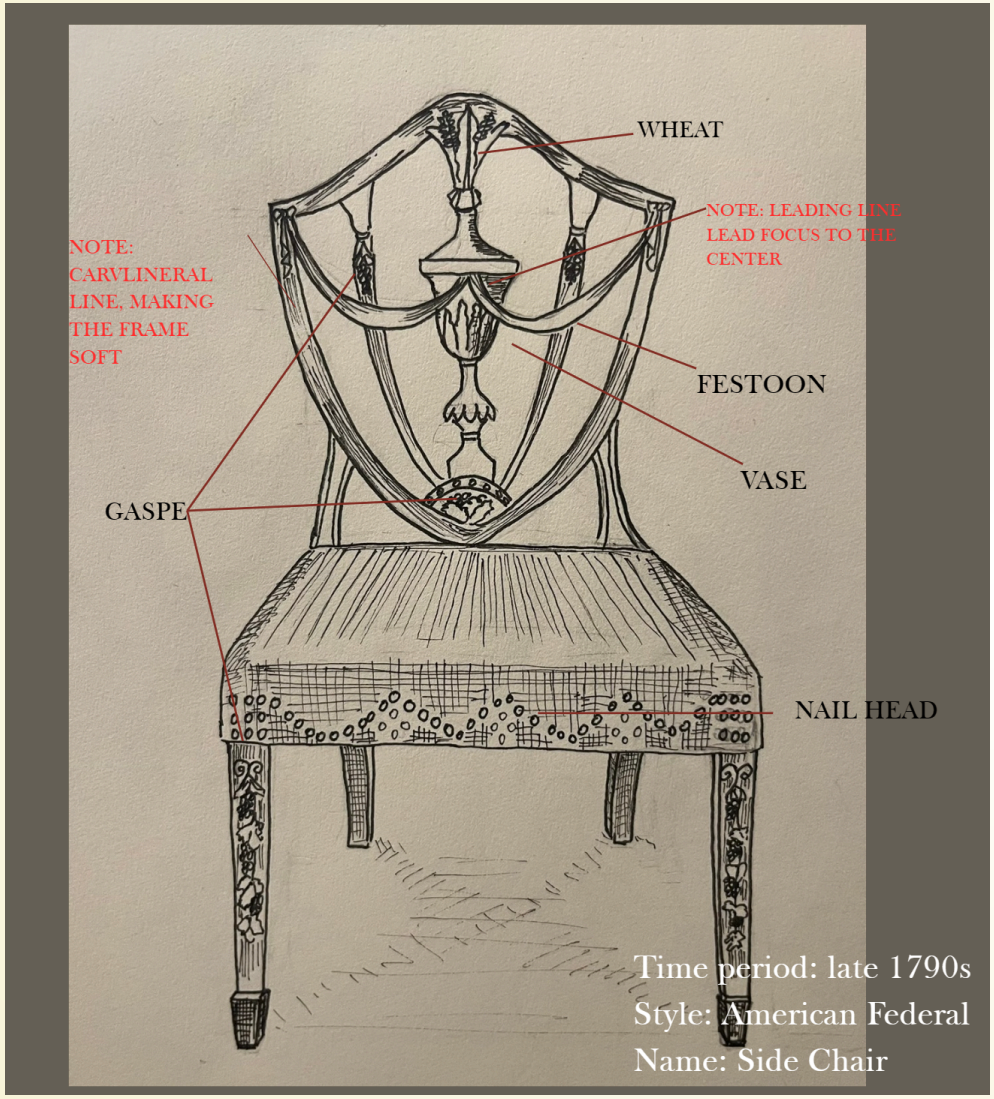




Figure 3: Side Chair

GENERAL INFORMATION

LOCATION

Salem, Massachusetts, United States

DESIGNER'S NAME

Samuel McIntire

YEAR OF FABRICATION

1794-1799

MATERIALS AND MOTIFS

MATERIALS

- Mahogany
- Ebony
- Ash
- Birch
- White Pine

MOTIFS

- Grapes
- Wheat Sheaf
- Festoon
- Vase
- Shield



Figure 3: Side chair



Figure 4: Samuel McIntire

CONSTRUCTION METHODS

Construction records are limited; According to Boschetto (2026), chairs from this period were mainly joined.

1. Cut a projecting end (tenon) on one piece of wood
2. Cut a matching socket (mortise) in the other
3. Fit them together and secure with glue or a peg

Note: The image shows modern joinery. Hand-cut traditional joints are usually uneven, serving as a clue for identifing original Federal-period chairs from mechine-cut copy copies (Underhill, 2026).

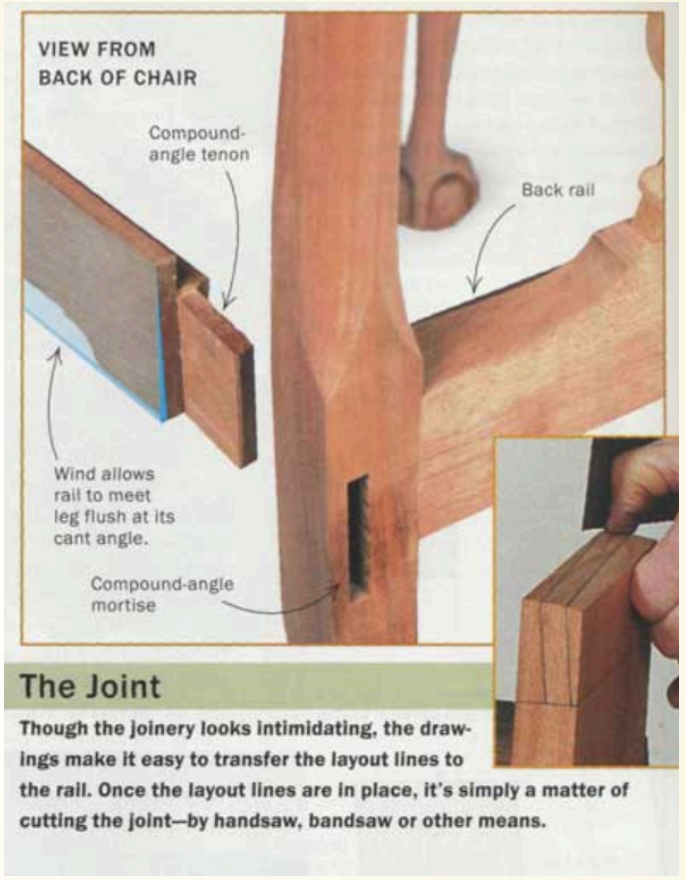


Figure 5: Joinery Illustration, Source: Fine Woodworking, (143), 61

MOTIFS AND TIME

- In the mid-18th century, the excavations at Pompeii triggered the neoclassical revolution. European designers extracted inspiration from uncovered artifacts, influencing American designers in the meantime.
- American Federal style shared similar motifs with Ancient Rome, due to the influences from Neoclassicism, while some design language was modified to adopt American values at that time
- For instance, urns refer to ancient Roman funerary vessels, but in Federal design, they meant the timelessness of republican virtue (Underhill, 2026).



Figure 6: Glass urn excavated from Pompeii

MOTIFS AND TIME

- American Federal Style emerged with the formation of the USA, so celebrating the development became the theme at that time (Thurlow,2019)
- This chair features several motifs associated with harvest and agriculture, including wheat stalks and grape clusters, reflecting the celebration of harvest
- The grasp pattern may suggest a connection to Salem, where the chair was made, a famous wine-brewing region.
- This chair shows a strong influence from Hepplewhite, inheriting key design elements such as the shield-shaped backrest.



Figure 7: A side chair based on a plate in Hepplewhite'sThe Cabinet Maker and Upholsterer's Guild

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FIGURE CREDITS

Figure 1: The Metropolitan Museum of Art. (n.d.). Parlor from the James Duncan Jr. house, Haverhill, Massachusetts. THEMET. https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/4927

Figure 2: The Metropolitan Museum of Art. (n.d.). Parlor from the James Duncan Jr. house, Haverhill, Massachusetts. THEMET. https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/4927

Figure 3: The Metropolitan Museum of Art. (n.d.). Side Chair. THEMET. https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/1674

Figure 4: Holy Cross College. (n.d.). Samuel McIntire. https://college.holycross.edu/faculty/wziobro/ClassicalAmerica/McIntireHP.htm

Figure 5 Neptune, W. (2000, August). Compound-angle joinery. Fine Woodworking, (143), 61. http://woodtools.nov.ru/mag/fww_2000_143/fww_2000_143_61.jpg

Figure 6 Western Australian Museum. (n.d.). Daily life in Pompeii. https://museum.wa.gov.au/pompeii2010/daily-life/objects/index.html

Figure 7 The Metropolitan Museum of Art. (n.d.). Side Chair https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/826278